

General Motors Brand Perception Research Report

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Purpose

The purpose of this survey research was to evaluate consumer perceptions of General Motors (GM) and compare the company with key competitors in the automotive market. The research examined how consumers viewed GM and its major vehicle brands, including Chevrolet, GMC, Buick, and Cadillac, compared with Ford and Tesla. The study focused on both unaided and aided brand awareness as well as the characteristics and attributes consumers associated with each company.

The research was designed to better understand GM's current position in the automotive market compared with Ford and Tesla. Both unaided and aided responses were collected to examine what consumers thought of the companies on their own as well as how they rated specific characteristics when prompted.

The study was designed to answer the following research questions:

1. How aware and familiar were consumers with GM compared with Ford and Tesla?
2. What characteristics did consumers associate with GM, Ford, and Tesla?
3. Which brand attributes were most strongly associated with GM compared with its competitors?
4. How did consumers' perceptions of GM differ among consumer segments?

The results were intended to help General Motors better understand how consumers viewed the company compared with its competitors. The findings could help GM identify areas where the company was viewed positively, areas where competitors were viewed more favorably, and opportunities for improvement. GM could use this information to guide future marketing decisions and determine which strengths to emphasize when communicating to consumers.

Methodology

The survey was created using Qualtrics and was available for online participation from August 12 through August 16, 2026. An anonymous survey link was initially shared through Facebook. Additional participation was encouraged by having potential participants tagged through the Facebook post and by asking family members to participate near the end of the collection period. These additional efforts were used to increase participation before the survey closed.

A total of 22 responses were received through the anonymous survey link. One response was incomplete and was excluded from the analysis, resulting in a final sample of 21 usable responses. Since the survey was shared through an anonymous social media link and personal contacts, the exact number of people who had the opportunity to participate could not be determined. Based on this, an exact response rate could not be accurately calculated.

Sample Size Statement: *For this study, the target population was estimated to be 21.6 million. The final sample was 21. At the 95% confidence level, this study had a margin of error of $\pm 21.5\%$.*

The original sampling plan identified an ideal sample size of 1,067 participants, which would have provided a margin of error (MOE) of $\pm 3\%$ at the 95% confidence level. The final sample of 21 resulted in a much larger MOE of $\pm 21.5\%$. This difference was expected with the smaller sample size collected for the course project and means the results provide a less precise estimate of the views of the overall target population.

Study Limitations

Several limitations should be considered when interpreting the results of this study. These limitations affect how confidently the findings can be applied to the larger target population.

Sample Size and Margin of Error

The final sample of 21 participants was much smaller than the ideal sample of 1,067 identified in the original sampling plan. As shown by the increase in the calculated margin of error from $\pm 3\%$ to $\pm 21.5\%$, results from the smaller sample provide less precision when estimating the views of the larger target population. Since individual responses have a greater influence on the overall results in a small sample, the findings should be interpreted with caution when considering the broader new-vehicle market.

Convenience Sampling and Participant Selection

The survey used convenience sampling because participants were recruited through social media and personal contacts rather than being randomly selected from the target population. This approach was appropriate for the limited time and resources available for the course project, but it meant that members of the target population did not have an equal chance of being selected.

Participants also chose whether or not to participate after receiving or seeing the survey link. This might have attracted individuals who were more interested in the survey topic than others, which could create some bias in the results. These factors limit how confidently the findings can be applied to the overall target population.

Target-Market Qualification

The original target population focused on U.S. households likely to purchase or lease a new vehicle within the next 12 months. However, the final survey did not include a screening question to confirm that participants met this qualification. With that said, some participants might not have been part of the specific target population the study was intended to represent.

This should be considered when applying the survey findings to the broader new-vehicle market. Responses from individuals who are not currently considering a new vehicle might still provide useful information about general brand perceptions, but their opinions may differ from those of consumers who are actively in the market for a new vehicle.

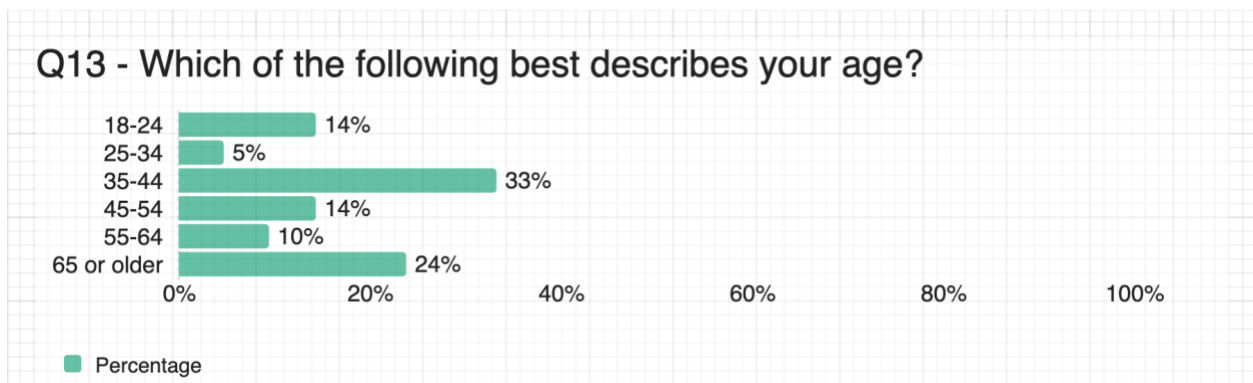
Representation of the Target Population

The final sample wasn't structured to match the demographic composition of the target population. Although respondents represented a range of ages and household income levels, some groups were more heavily represented than others, including ages 35-44 at 33% and female respondents at 67%. Since convenience sampling was used rather than stratified random sampling proposed in the original plan, these differences could influence the overall results. The demographic composition of the sample should therefore be considered when applying the findings to the larger target population.

Respondent Profile

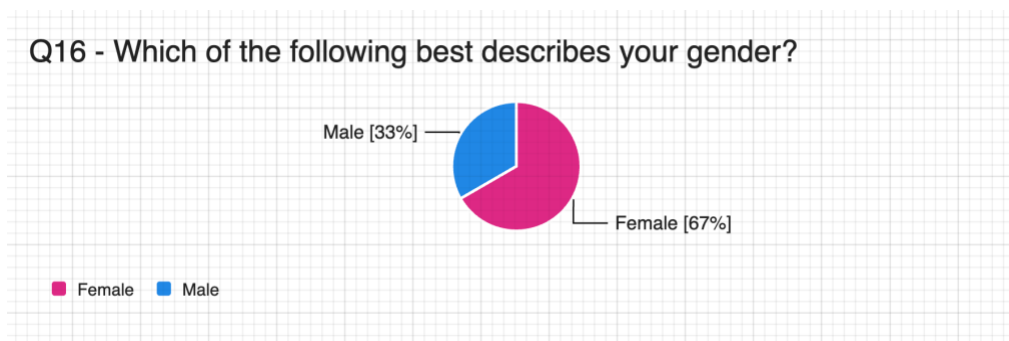
The respondent profile provides an overview of the demographic characteristics of the 21 participants included in the final sample. Age, gender, and annual household income are summarized below using percentages to show the overall composition of the sample.

Age



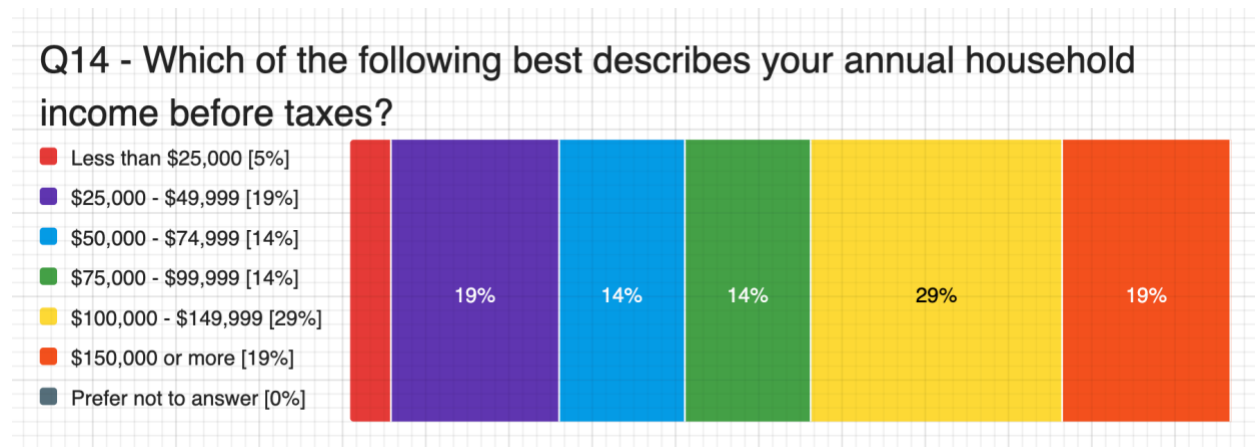
Respondents were represented across all six age ranges, although the distribution varied between them. Adults ages 35-44 made up the largest portion of the sample at 33%, while ages 25-34 represented the smallest at 5%, with a difference of 28 percentage points. The remaining age groups ranged from 10% to 24%, indicating that the sample included a mix of age groups despite the higher concentration of respondents ages 35-44.

Gender



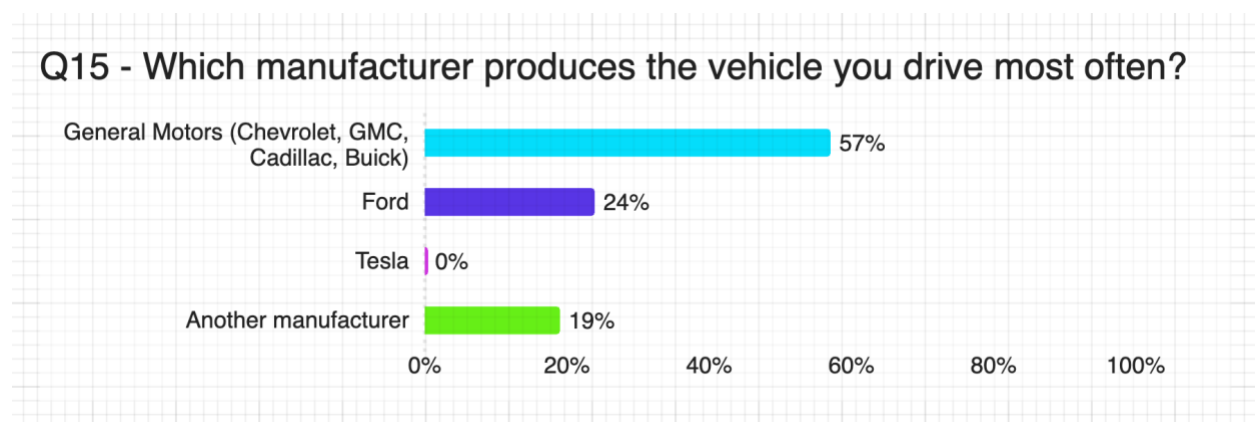
Female respondents made up the majority of the sample at 67%, compared with 33% male respondents. This represents a 24-percentage-point difference between the two groups, showing that the sample was more heavily represented by female participants.

Annual Household Income



Annual household income was distributed across all six reported income ranges, with the largest group earning \$100,000 – 149,999 at 29%. The smallest group reported an income below \$25,000 at 5%, a difference of 24 percentage points. The remaining income ranges were relatively close, accounting for either 14% or 19% of respondents, indicating that the sample included participants across a variety of household income levels.

Current Vehicle Manufacturer



General Motors vehicles were driven most often by 57% of respondents, making GM the most represented manufacturer in the sample. Ford followed at 24%, creating a 33-percentage-point difference between the two competitors. It is interesting to note that while 19% reported driving another manufacturer, 0% reported driving a Tesla. The high percentage of GM drivers is important to consider when interpreting later brand awareness and perception results.

Executive Summary

Brand Awareness

General Motors showed strong brand awareness within the sample. GM received the highest aided familiarity score at 3.71, followed closely by Ford (3.43), while Tesla was considerably lower (1.95). Unaided awareness was strongest for Ford, although Chevrolet was also mentioned by nearly all participants.

Brand Perceptions and Attributes

GM's strongest aided attributes were vehicle variety and reputation, both with mean scores of 4.10, while environmental responsibility (2.90) and value for the price (3.10) were its weakest. Ford was GM's strongest competitor and received higher ratings for reputation, reliability, quality, and value. Tesla stood apart for innovation, advanced technology, and environmental responsibility. Purchase consideration was also favorable for GM, with a mean of 3.86, equal to Ford but considerably higher than Tesla at 2.00.

Differences by Segment

Perceptions of GM's value differed across age groups. Participants ages 25-34 rated GM's value highest at 4.00, while those ages 45-54 rated it lowest at 2.67. This difference suggests that GM's value proposition may appeal differently across consumer age groups, although the small sample means these findings should be interpreted cautiously.

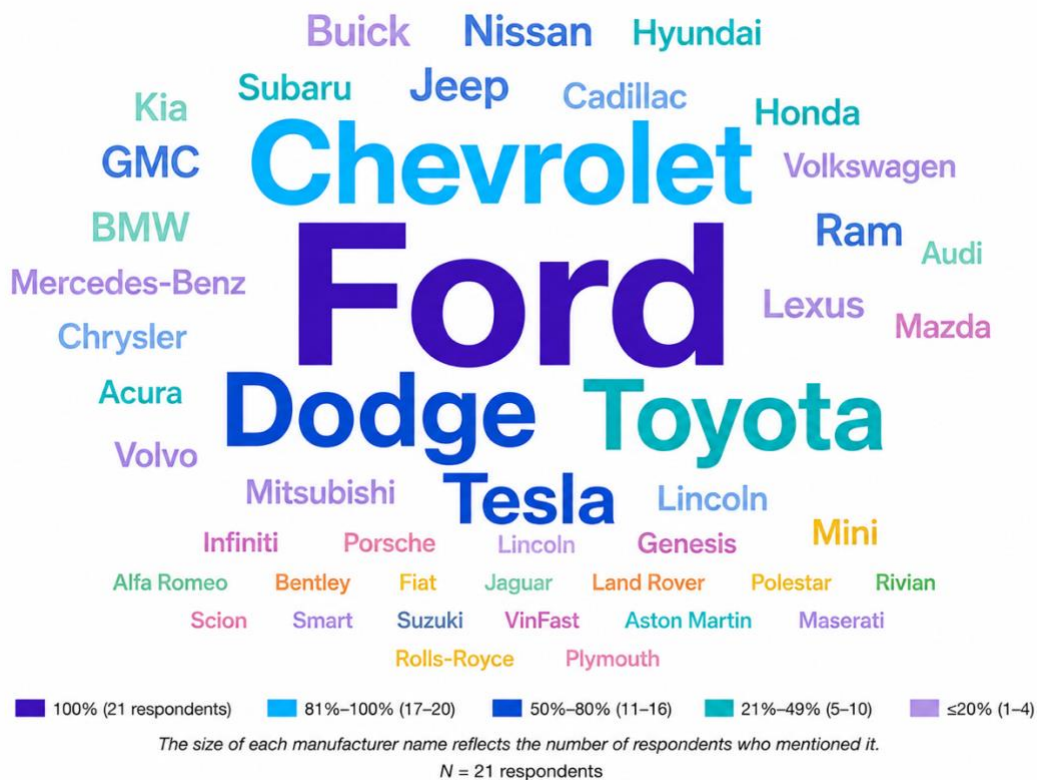
Recommendations

GM should continue emphasizing its strong reputation, broad vehicle selection, and overall brand familiarity while working to strengthen perceptions of value and environmental responsibility. The company should also consider how value is communicated to different age groups, particularly consumers ages 45-54. Finally, GM should continue strengthening its positioning around innovation and advanced technology to better compete with Tesla while maintaining the traditional strengths that position it well against Ford.

Detailed Findings

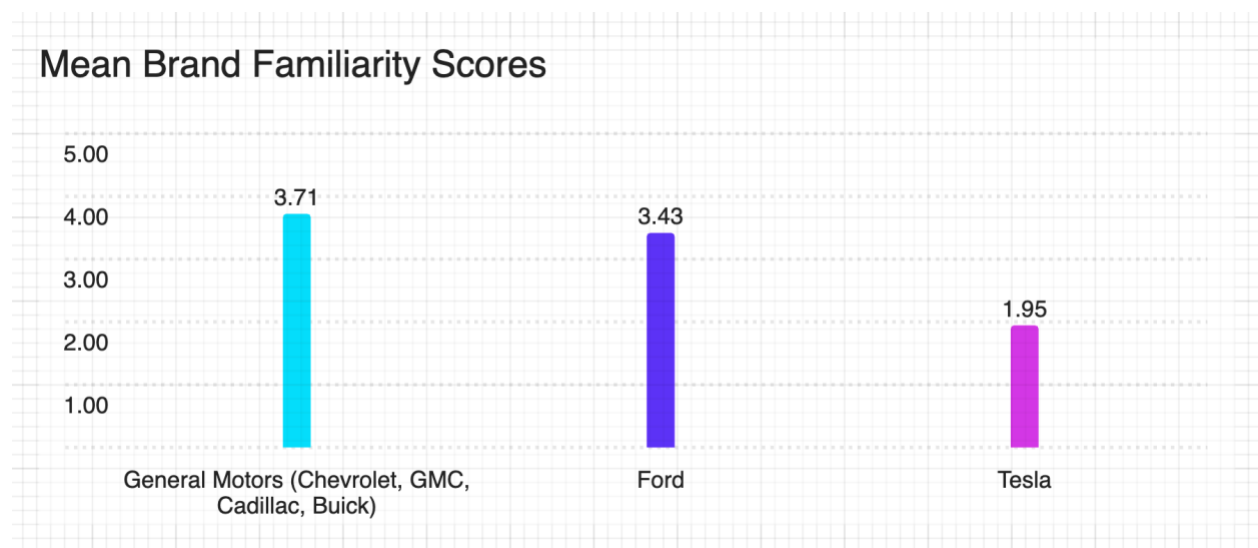
The detailed findings summarize the key results from the 21 usable survey responses. The results are organized around brand awareness, consumer perceptions, and brand attributes to compare General Motors with Ford and Tesla. Visuals are included throughout the section to highlight important patterns and differences within the sample.

Unaided Awareness



Ford had the strongest unaided awareness, with all of the 21 respondents mentioning the manufacturer, followed by Chevrolet, which was mentioned by nearly all respondents. Dodge, Toyota, and Tesla also stood out among the most frequently recalled manufacturers. Beyond these leading brands, respondents identified a wide range of other manufacturers, showing broad awareness of the automotive market. The strong presence of both GM brands and major competitors provides useful context for the aided awareness and brand perception results that follow.

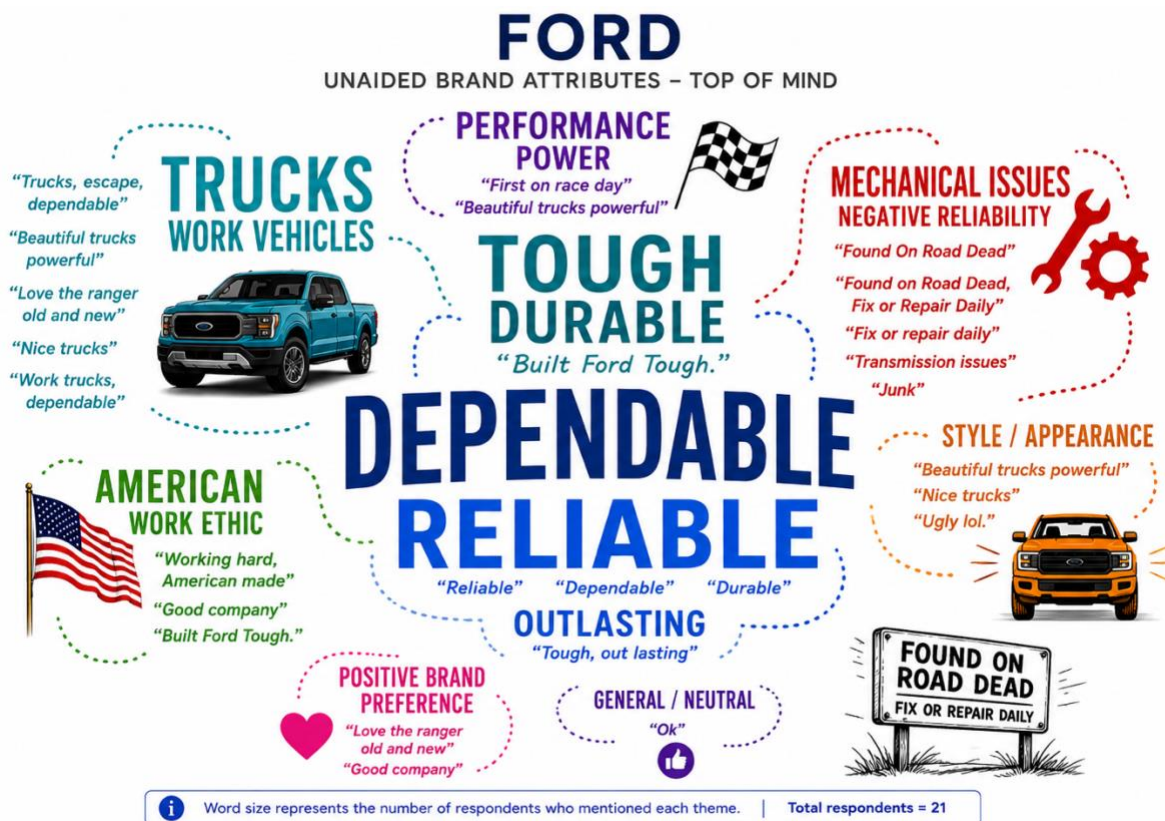
Aided Awareness



As shown above, General Motors had the highest mean familiarity score at 3.71, followed closely by Ford at 3.43. The difference between the two brands was relatively small at 0.28 points, suggesting respondents had similar levels of familiarity with GM and Ford. Tesla had a considerably lower mean score of 1.95, falling 1.76 points below GM and 1.48 points below Ford. Overall, the results indicate much stronger familiarity with GM and Ford among this sample compared with Tesla.

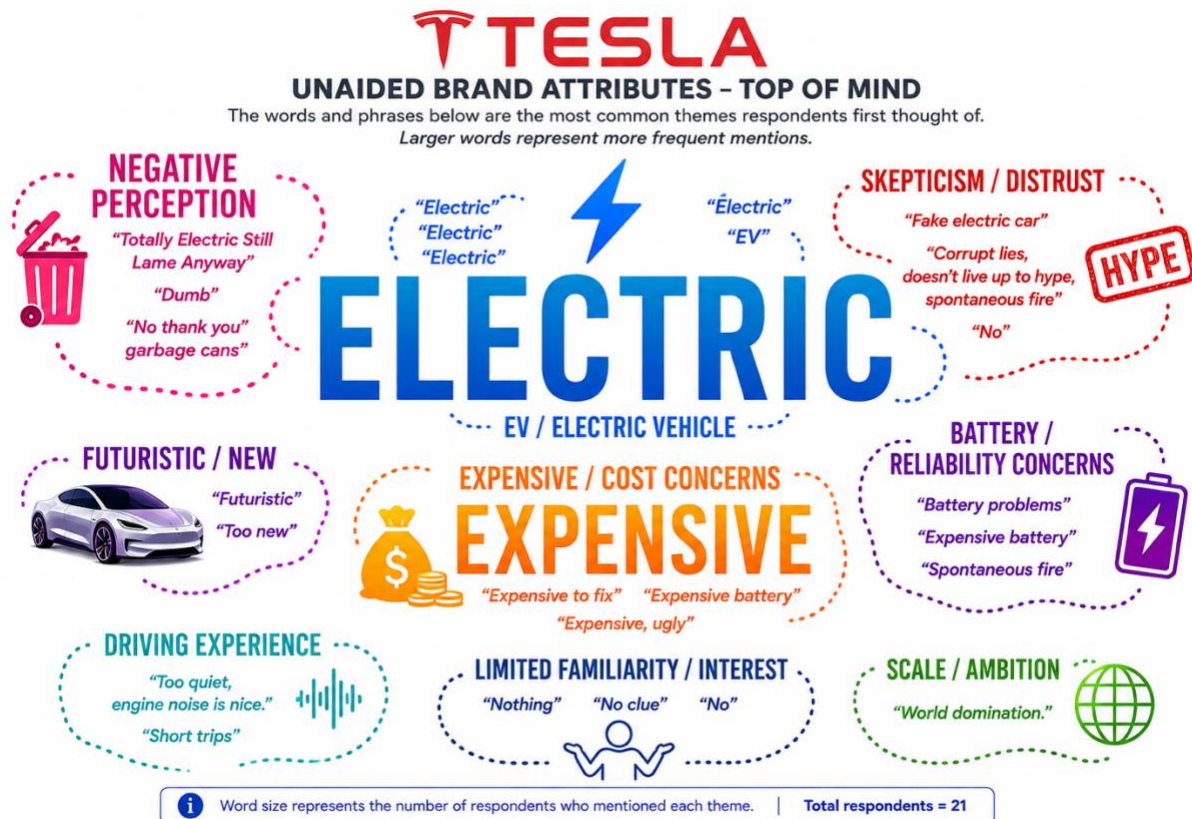
The General Motors word cloud above groups similar responses into broader themes while also including examples of the words and phrases used by participants. Larger themes represent stronger or more frequently mentioned associations. For example, comments such as "*lasts a long time*," "*trusted*," and "*outlasting*" support the larger reliability theme, while "*big engine*" and "*Chevy Tough*" contribute to the performance and power theme. Overall, reliability and quality were the strongest associations with GM, while participants also connected the company with American heritage, vehicle variety, performance, and style. A smaller number of negative comments related to quality and value were also identified, showing that perceptions were generally positive but not entirely consistent across the sample.

Ford



Ford responses showed a strong association with dependability, reliability, toughness, and durability, with several participants also specifically connecting the brand with trucks and work vehicles. Comments such as "Built Ford Tough," "work trucks, dependable," and "working hard, American made" helped form these larger positive themes. At the same time, the responses showed a noticeable contrast, as several participants mentioned mechanical concerns or phrases such as "Fix or Repair Daily" and "Found On Road Dead." Overall, the results suggest that Ford has a strong reputation for trucks, toughness, and dependability among this sample, although some negative perceptions related to reliability remain.

Tesla



Tesla was most strongly associated with electric vehicles, with "electric" appearing repeatedly throughout the responses and forming the dominant theme in the visual. Cost was another noticeable association, with participants describing Tesla as expensive and specifically mentioning the cost of repairs and batteries. Smaller themes related to Tesla being futuristic or new also appeared, showing that participants clearly connected the brand with newer automotive technology.

At the same time, many of the remaining associations were negative or skeptical. Participants mentioned battery and reliability concerns, limited driving range or experience, and several strongly negative opinions about the brand. Some participants also provided responses such as "nothing," "no clue," or "no," suggesting limited familiarity or interest. Overall, Tesla had a very clear identity as an electric vehicle brand among this sample, but that awareness was accompanied by concerns about cost, reliability, and the brand itself.

What Makes Each Brand Stand Out

WHAT MAKES EACH BRAND STAND OUT FROM COMPETITORS?

Key themes from open-ended responses | Total respondents = 21

 GENERAL MOTORS (Chevrolet, GMC, Cadillac, Buick)			 FORD			 TESLA		
TOP THEMES	% OF RESPONDENTS	EXAMPLE RESPONSES	TOP THEMES	% OF RESPONDENTS	EXAMPLE RESPONSES	TOP THEMES	% OF RESPONDENTS	EXAMPLE RESPONSES
 VALUE & AFFORDABILITY	19%	• "Price" • "Accessible mass market value."	 TRUCKS & PICKUP LEADERSHIP	29%	• "Unmatched dominance in the pickup truck market." • "Nice quality trucks"	 ELECTRIC & EV LEADERSHIP	43%	• "Electric" • "You don't need gas"
 QUALITY & RELIABILITY	19%	• "Quality" • "Dependable, safe, service departments are usually high quality"	 DURABILITY & BUILT STRONG	24%	• "Built strong" • "Runs a long time"	 COST / EXPENSIVE	24%	• "Expensive" • "Expensive"
 DURABILITY & LONG LASTING	14%	• "Long lasting" • "Runs forever, find replacement parts easily"	 HERITAGE & LONG STANDING HISTORY	19%	• "Been around forever" • "One of the first automakers"	 TECHNOLOGY & INNOVATION	24%	• "Can start the car with your phone" • "Advanced technology"
 WIDE RANGE OF BRANDS & OPTIONS	14%	• "Diversity" • "Has many different brands and lasts for many miles"	 REPUTATION & DEPENDABILITY	19%	• "Ford strong trucks" • "Reputation"	 ENVIRONMENTAL FOCUS	14%	• "Cares about pollution." • "Better gas mileage"
 QUALITY INTERIORS & LUXURY FEEL	10%	• "They have excellent interiors" • "They look and feel luxury"	 DEALERSHIP AVAILABILITY	10%	• "They seem to have more dealerships"	 SPECIAL PERKS / FEATURES	10%	• "Get special parking way out in the back for charging"
 BRAND AWARENESS & POPULARITY	10%	• "Comercials" • "Popular"	 ICONIC & RECOGNIZABLE	5%	• "Iconic" • "Generational stand out"	 FUTURE ORIENTED	10%	• "The future" • "Brought new light/interest to the electric market"
 PARTS & SERVICE ACCESSIBILITY	5%	• "Replacement parts are not to expensive" • "Cheap versions of competitive manufacturers"	 DOWNSIDES / ISSUES MENTIONED	10%	• "They break a lot" • "Hard to start when it's cold"	 NEGATIVE / SKEPTICAL OPINIONS	19%	• "A joke of a company" • "Not the status symbol it was hyped to be"
 GM stands out for its value, wide range of brands, reliability, and long-lasting quality.			 Ford stands out for its leadership in trucks, strength, long history, and strong reputation.			 Tesla stands out for leading the electric market with advanced technology, but is also viewed as expensive and polarizing by some.		

 Percentages may total more than 100% because some respondents mentioned multiple themes.

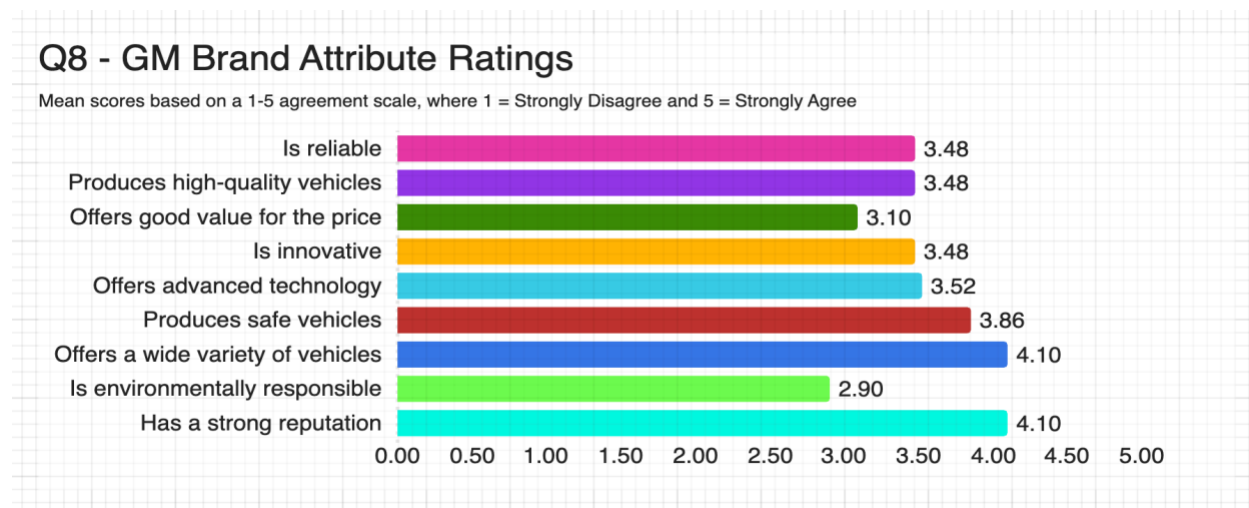
Percentages reflect the number of respondents (out of 21) who mentioned each theme.

General Motors stood primarily for quality, reliability, longevity, and variety. Participants frequently mentioned that GM vehicles last a long time, are dependable, and have replacement parts that are relatively easy or inexpensive to obtain. GM was also recognized for offering many different brands and vehicle options, suggesting that its ability to serve a wide range of consumers is an important part of how participants distinguish it from competitors.

Ford showed some similarities to GM, particularly around dependability, longevity, and its long history in the automotive industry. However, Ford was much more strongly connected with trucks, strength, and reputation, with participants repeatedly mentioning work trucks, pickup trucks, and phrases related to being built strong. This suggests while GM was viewed as standing out through its broad selection and overall reliability, Ford had a more concentrated identity built around trucks and its established reputation.

Tesla differed considerably from both traditional manufacturers. Participants most often described Tesla in terms of electric vehicles, technology, and innovation, including comments about advanced technology and helping lead the shift toward electric vehicles. At the same time, Tesla received more mixed reactions, with concerns about price and several openly negative responses. Overall, the comparison shows three fairly distinct positions with this sample: GM for variety and dependable quality, Ford for trucks and strength, and Tesla for electric vehicles and technology, although perceptions of Tesla appeared more divided than those of GM and Ford.

Aided Brand Attributes

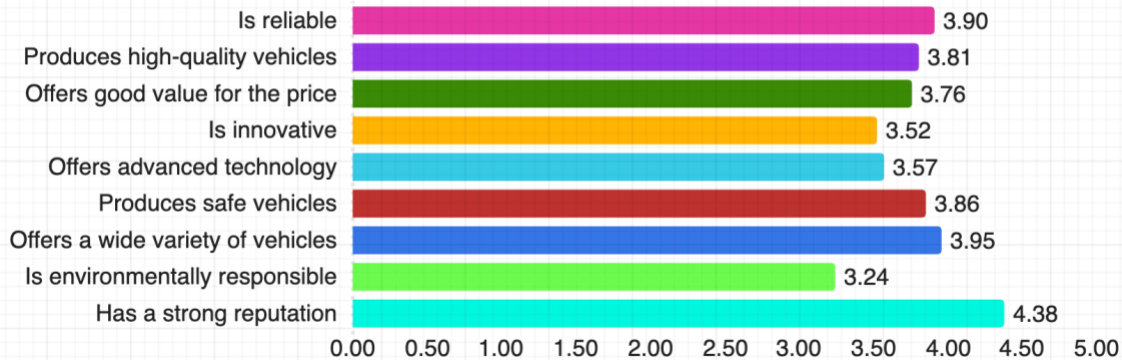


General Motors received its highest mean scores for offering a wide variety of vehicles and having a strong reputation, both at 4.10. Safety was another strong scoring area, with a mean score of 3.86. These results suggest that participants particularly recognize GM for its broad vehicle selection, established reputation, and vehicle safety. Reliability, quality, innovation, and advanced technology also received moderately positive ratings, with mean scores ranging from 3.48 to 3.52.

GM's weaker ratings were related to value for the price and environmental responsibility. Value received a mean score of 3.10, while environmental responsibility was GM's lowest-rated attribute at 2.90 and the only attribute to fall below the neutral midpoint of 3.00. This suggests that although participants generally viewed GM positively across most attributes, environmental responsibility might be an area where the brand has a weaker consumer perception. Whether GM actually leads or falls behind its competitors on these attributes will become clearer when its results are compared directly with Ford and Tesla.

Q9 - Ford Brand Attribute Ratings

Mean scores based on a 1-5 agreement scale, where 1 = Strongly Disagree and 5 = Strongly Agree

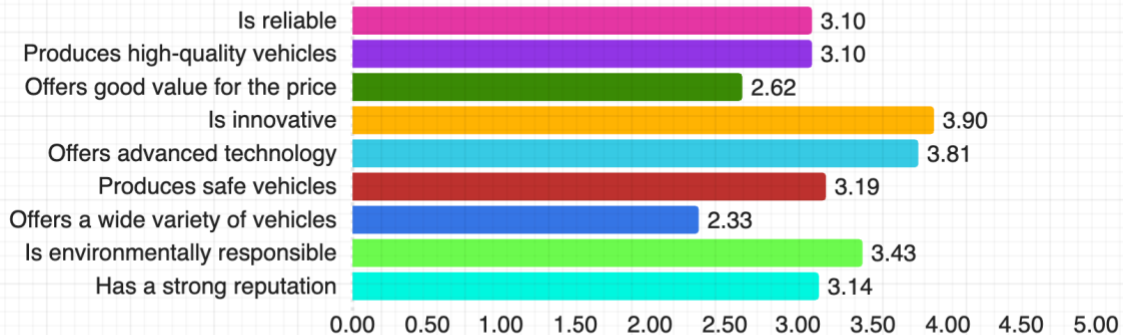


Ford received its highest mean score for having a strong reputation at 4.38, making it the strongest-rated attribute for the brand. Other highly rated areas included offering a wide variety of vehicles (3.95), reliability (3.90), and vehicle safety (3.86). Quality and value also received relatively strong ratings of 3.81 and 3.76, showing that participants generally viewed Ford positively across several traditional vehicle attributes.

Ford's lower ratings were concentrated around innovation, advanced technology, and environmental responsibility. Innovation received a mean score of 3.52 and advanced technology scored 3.57, while environmental responsibility was the lowest-rated attribute at 3.24. Even so, all nine attributes remained above the neutral midpoint of 3.00. Overall, Ford's results suggest that its strongest perceptions among participants center on its reputation, vehicle selection, reliability, and safety, while environmental responsibility appears to be its greatest opportunity for improvement.

Q10 - Tesla Brand Attribute Ratings

Mean scores based on a 1-5 agreement scale, where 1 = Strongly Disagree and 5 = Strongly Agree

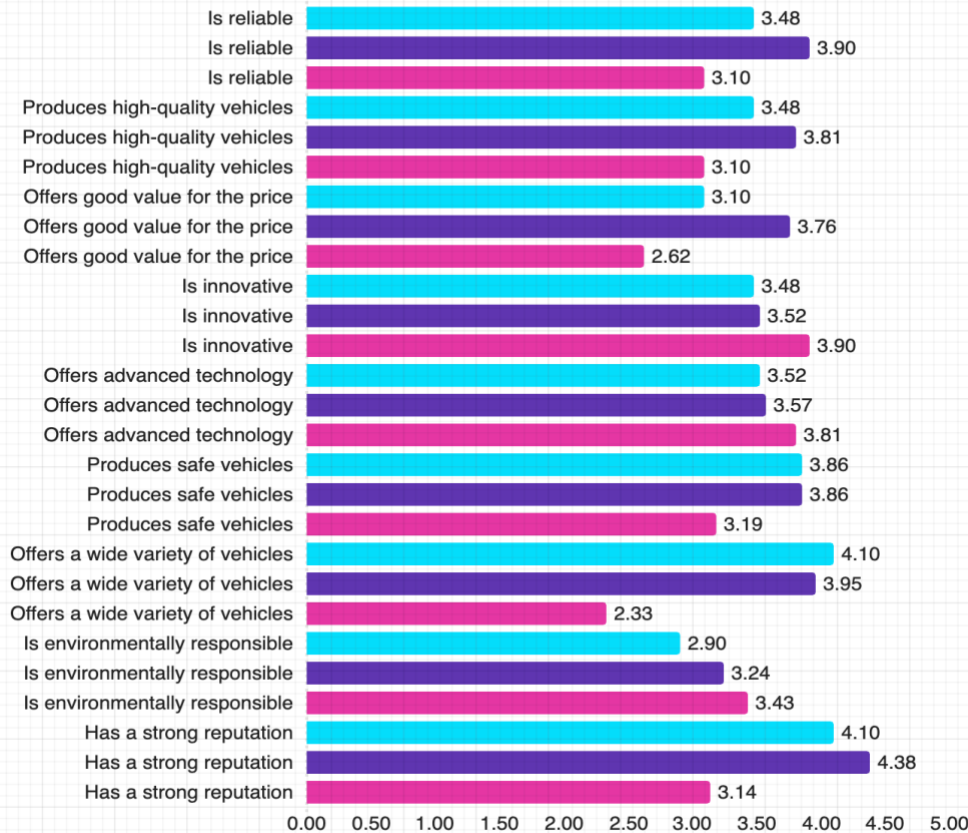


Tesla received its highest mean scores for innovation at 3.90 and advanced technology at 3.81, making these its strongest-rated attributes. Environmental responsibility was also viewed relatively positively, receiving a mean score of 3.43. These results suggest that participants primarily associate Tesla's strengths with its technology, innovation, and position in the electric vehicle market. Reliability, quality, safety, and reputation were closer to neutral, with mean scores ranging from 3.10 to 3.19.

Tesla's weakest ratings were for value for the price (2.62) and offering a wide variety of vehicles (2.33). Both scores fell below the neutral midpoint of 3.00, with vehicle variety standing out as the lowest-rated attribute overall. Unlike its strong technology-focused ratings, these results suggest participants were less positive about Tesla's product selection and the value its vehicles provide for the price. Overall, Tesla appears to have a clearly defined strength in innovation and technology, but participants' perceptions were more mixed across several traditional vehicle attributes.

Brand Attributes Comparison

GM = light blue | Ford = dark purple | Tesla = light purple



The comparison shows clear differences in how participants viewed the three brands. Ford performed strongest on several vehicle attributes, including reliability (3.90), quality (3.81), value for the price (3.76), and reputation (4.38). GM's clearest advantage was vehicle variety, where it received the highest mean score at 4.10, while GM and Ford tied for safety at 3.86. These results suggest that Ford stood out most for established strengths such as reputation, reliability, and value, while GM's strongest competitive position was the range of vehicles it offers.

Tesla stood apart in a different set of attributes, receiving the highest ratings for innovation (3.90), advanced technology (3.81), and environmental responsibility (3.43). However, Tesla also received notably lower ratings for value (2.62) and vehicle variety (2.33), showing a clear contrast between its technology-focused strengths and more traditional attributes. For GM, the comparison suggests an opportunity to build on its strong reputation and broad vehicle selection while strengthening perceptions in areas such as value and environmental responsibility, where competitors received higher ratings.

Purchase Consideration Statistics

Scores based on a 1-5 agreement scale, where 1 = strongly disagree and 5 = strongly agree

Field	Min	Max	Mean	Median	Standard Deviation	Variance	Responses
I would consider purchasing or leasing a General Motors vehicle (Chevrolet, GMC, Cadillac, Buick)	1.00	5.00	3.86	5.00	1.46	2.12	21
I would consider purchasing or leasing a Ford vehicle	1.00	5.00	3.86	4.00	1.12	1.27	21
I would consider purchasing or leasing a Tesla vehicle	1.00	5.00	2.00	2.00	1.15	1.33	21

General Motors and Ford received identical mean purchase consideration scores of 3.86, indicating relatively positive consideration for both brands. However, GM had a median of 5.00, compared with 4.00 for Ford, while GM also had greater variation in responses. Its standard deviation was 1.46 and variance 2.12, compared with 1.12 and 1.27 for Ford. This suggests that although the average scores were the same, participants were less consistent in their purchase consideration of GM.

Tesla received a considerably lower mean and median score of 2.00, showing much lower purchase consideration among participants. Its standard deviation of 1.15 and variance of 1.33 indicate some variation in responses, but considerably less than GM. Overall, the results show similar average purchase consideration for GM and Ford, while Tesla fell well below both brands within this sample.

Differences by Segments

To examine whether perceptions of General Motors differed across demographic groups, participants' ratings of GM's value for the price were compared by age. Mean scores were used to show how perceptions varied across the six age groups represented in this sample.

GM Value Perception by Age Group						
Mean scores based on a 1-5 agreement scale, where 1 = Strongly Disagree and 5 = Strongly Agree						
Field	18-24	25-34	35-44	45-54	55-64	65 or older
Mean	3.00	4.00	3.14	2.67	3.50	3.00

Perceptions of GM's value for the price varied across age groups. Participants ages 25-34 gave GM the highest mean score at 4.00, while those ages 45-54 gave the lowest rating of 2.67, a difference of 1.33 points. The remaining age groups were closer together, with mean scores ranging from 3.00 to 3.50. These results suggest that GM's value might be viewed more favorably by some age groups than others within this sample.

To determine whether these differences are also present in the larger target population, a one-way ANOVA could be used. This test is appropriate because it would compare the mean value rating across more than two independent age groups to determine whether the differences between the groups are statistically significant rather than simply differences observed within this sample.